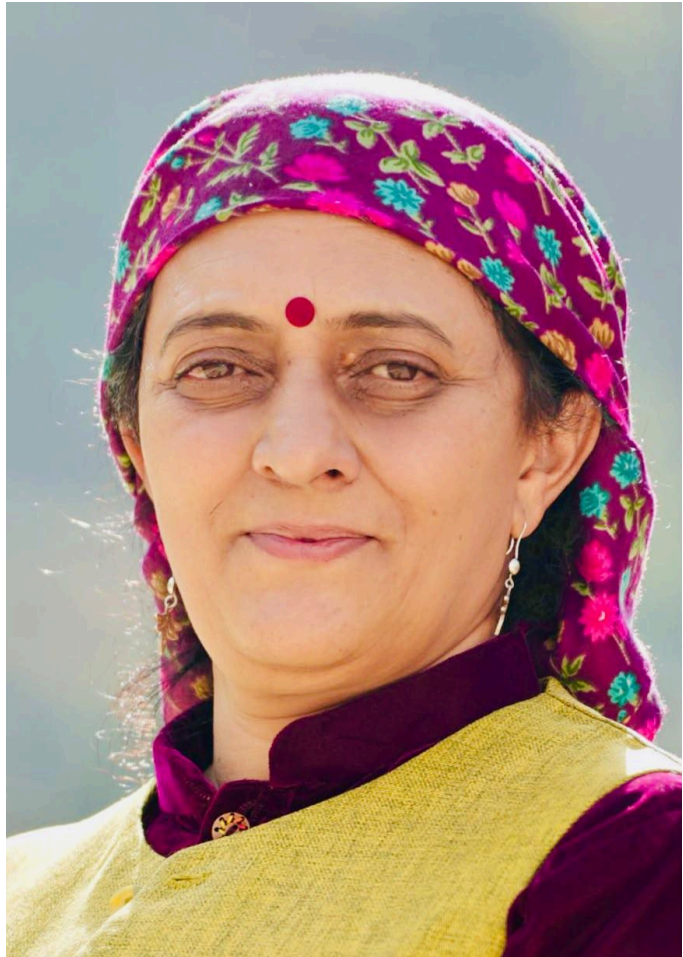


From a Traditional Delicacy to a Growing Brand: A Journey of Innovation and Collective Entrepreneurship

Every great journey begins with a small idea, just as a small seed grows into a big tree when nurtured with care, an idea can blossom into a successful venture when supported by dedication and continuous effort. This is the story of Poonam Chauhan Ji from **Narkanda, Himachal Pradesh**. She started her entrepreneurial journey in December 2022 with a small idea of producing cultural cuisine named moddi. The idea came to her at a wedding function where she observed moddi being served to the guests. There she came up with this idea of why keeping moddi limited to the local region only rather, this product representing cultural ritual must reach a wider audience. This thought laid the foundation of the entrepreneurial journey which ultimately led to the establishment of kotgarh kitchen, a brand dedicated to produce and sell locally processed food products. Having graduated with the degree of [B.Sc](#) and further B.ed , she had been living in Delhi.



After returning to her village she encountered the challenge of limited employment opportunities so eventually she started looking for other livelihood options. After some time, she got to know about the self help groups (SHGs) and joined one in May 2022. Poonam Ji believed in the power of collective entrepreneurship, because of which she formed a group of around 18-20 women, all of whom were having the vision of building a powerful and sustainable business. Although most of the activities are being carried out collectively with the help of smaller teams within the shg, Poonam Ji continues to be

known as the Founder of Kotgarh Kitchen brand, and is committed towards its growth and success as a result of which she keeps on encouraging other women to participate in it.

Like every other women entrepreneur out there, Poonam Ji also had to face many challenges in establishing and making her brand. One of the biggest hurdles was the lack of financial resources, for which she invested her own savings into the business. Although she has taken her investment back when the business started making enough profits. Another bigger challenge was related to the marketing of the product as it was really tough for them to promote and showcase their product outside the local region. The National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM) helped them with this, by giving them the opportunity to participate in summer festivals and exhibitions that helped the group in promoting and showing their products to a wider audience base. However, marketing continues to be a big challenge today as well but she is handling them effectively by promoting the products through online marketplaces such as Amazon, over which she is soon going to have her first product listing. Another significant challenge that the team handles efficiently is the maintenance of costs within an acceptable range, as the inputs for the raw materials have to be procured from outside the village which ultimately results in making the product costlier.

The Training of Financial and Digital Literacy helped the group in strengthening its marketing capabilities by making them aware of the potential of Instagram as a product promoting tool. After the training the group made promotional posts for one of their products on it, and to their surprise the customer enquiries started coming as soon as they made the posts. This clearly reflects the power of digital marketing and encouraged them to use this further for promotion of other products as well. They acknowledged that this training made them acquire this skill, otherwise they might not have used it this soon. Poonam ji believes in Community development and welfare of the society because as soon as she and her team learned his skill, they made other women learn it also which clearly reflects her vision of collective entrepreneurship. For the upcoming future, she is very much optimistic about her brand Kotgrah kitchen. She is a remarkable example of how innovation and collective action can transform a traditional household product into a successful business opportunity. She has shown that when women combine the local knowledge with modern business practices, they can preserve cultural heritage, generate sustainable livelihood and inspire many others.